

E-tivity 2



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Risk, Ethics and Governance of AI

IN5103

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0.1 Research task: Option A

‘Do Artefacts have Politics?’ (Winner 1980) came at a time where emerging technologies with strong political impacts had outgrown *‘the theory of social determination of technology’*. Winner argued that technologies could not be seen as mere by-products of societal or economic forces. He introduced *‘the theory of technological politics’*, which does not look to replace the former but to widen it.

Winner presents two ways in which technology can be political, making use of multiple examples. For *‘Technical Arrangements as Forms of Order’*, his case study of Robert Moses’ New York bridges is the most well-known. Whether the overpasses were racist and classist, this was *Chinese whispers* (Joerges 1999) or Moses was just a naive designer (Canadian Centre for Architecture 2014), Winner’s argument stands the test of time.

The bridges present an unavoidable fact that makes them political. All 200 of them share a height that prohibits the passage of trucks and buses. Their mere existence shows a class imbalance and imposes a social reality. Exclusionary design is a great introductory example to show exactly what Winner meant by *‘Technical Arrangements as Forms of Order’*. These arrangements of metal and concrete come to this world to give an **order** to it unapologetically. And being aware of this is critical because, in his own words:

...technological innovations are similar to legislative acts or political foundings that establish a framework for public order that will endure over many generations. (Winner 1980, p. 128).

For *‘Inherently Political Technologies’*, the conversation turns less anecdotal and more philosophical. Winner talks about Lewis Mumford’s thesis where authoritarian technology and democratic technology coexist in the western world (Mumford 1964), about Friedrich Engels’s *‘On Authority’* Essay (Engels 1978), where Engels’s addresses what he refers to as naive anarchists. Winner also brings Plato’s Republic (Plato 2004) into the discussion and draws comparisons between the Greek and the German philosophers, highlighting that both used the ‘ship

at sea’ example, with the difference being that Plato was defending expert ruling, while Engel says that regardless of the political framework, some forms of technology are authoritarian.

Winner also presents Karl Marx (1906)’s *‘Capital’* thoughts on his volume one as an antithesis to Engel’s thinking. Thinking about a socialist revolution, Marx saw a potential ally in technology. Engel saw technology dictating workers’ lives (“The automatic machinery of the big factory is much more despotic than the small capitalists who employ workers ever have been”). And Marx acknowledged that (“the workman as a living appendage of the machine”), but believed that under different leadership, technological advancements could diversify the tasks for the proletariat and dissolve the division of labour.

But Winner’s point is that whether the oligarchs or the proletarians are pushing the social order, the truth is that *‘Inherently Political Technologies’* require those social frameworks. But it is a soft requirement. Plato wanted one competent captain in charge of the ship because it would lead to success, but other arrangements are possible. In other cases, Winner says, it might be a matter of compatibility; he mentions how solar advocates see this energy source as politically compatible with democracy. And in contrast, how the atomic bomb is inherently an authoritarian artefact. But what does this all mean?

...the issue has to do with ways in which choices about technology have important consequences for the form and quality of human associations. (Winner 1980, p. 131).

According to Winner, after carefully analysing the work of all these thinkers from various times, the single most important element that must be considered in terms of politics to decide if a technology should be adopted is humanity and social relationships. Even environmental concerns or remarkable income should be second to our humanity. Was it necessary to go over different philosophical viewpoints to reach this conclusion? I can understand that maybe it sounds obvious. However, if we apply this to the current AI landscape, everything feels backwards.

We see the US Congress asking AI CEOs like Sam Altman for advice in how to regulate them (United States Senate Committee on the Judiciary 2023).

We have individuals behind commercial Gen-AI models like Grok and ChatGPT fighting over money in court (Le Monde 2026). Meanwhile, the Pope is warning us not to build another tower of Babel and lose our humanity in the process (Leo XIV 2026). Winner continues his thoughts for a few more pages, he talks about Alfred D. Chandler’s work and Russell W. Ayres’s study about the economy and nuclear power. But more importantly, he communicates that he can’t settle any controversies but shares his personal views with honesty, highly political technologies of the 1980s and the potential impact on society. I shall do the same for our current time.

Remarkably, Winner’s conclusions are just as valid today as they ever were. Fifty years later, the priest and member of the United Nations’ High-level Advisory Body on Artificial Intelligence, Paolo Benanti, during a conference in Norway, says:

AI, when it changes people’s behaviour through nudging or pushing, acts “like a law,” if law is understood broadly as an instrument that shapes behaviour. (Benanti 2023*a*, 1:17:30).

In this context, he provides a very topical example. He presents an AI-generated image of Pope Francis wearing a puffer jacket (Figure 1). The relevant part, he says, is the author: a warehouse worker with no skill in graphic design but who, in a five-minute break, prompted Midjourney and generated an image that reached millions in just a few hours. This example is harmless, and as Benanti explains, basic anatomical knowledge and common sense are enough to dismiss the image depicting a real event. However, it shows how generative artificial intelligence (Gen-AI) as a service could be used to pollute communication channels with fake news. And it is not hard to imagine how people seeking power could abuse it.

Researcher Erik Reichborn-Kjennerud’s question: “What do we actually talk about when we talk about AI?” (Leine 2024) shows another political aspect of the matter. He shared his own definition and shared a concern, too. In simple terms, he defined AI as ‘the automation of thinking’. And he said that a large section of the industry is actively trying to keep the definition of AI terms unclear or blurred for their own purposes.



Figure 1: AI-generated image of Pope Francis in a white puffer coat -
Illustration credited to Midjourney. [Source: (Leine 2024)]

I find it critical to share my interpretation of what we commonly call Gen-AI. It consists mainly of probability concepts and attention theory put into practice to create a model that, like a black box, takes input (human language or content) and outputs unseen content. We can peek at the box, but what we see holds no meaning to humans. The ‘*black box*’ element already also brings ethical concerns (Mullins et al. 2021). But it also means that the paths for improvement are limited. It often requires more clean data. This is why there is an interest in building more data centres, to hold more and train more.

There is no denying it, the deep learning developments of recent years have generated a global political change that shows how AI falls under the two interpretations that Winner developed to describe how artefacts can be political. This was expected; Winner foresaw overlaps if the technology in question was complex. I believe that raising the collective level of political awareness around AI is the next critical step. I do not want the people leading AI to be greedy individuals who have forgotten that no material possessions leave this earth with us when we do. And I do not want AI development to be an arms race fuelled by fear, thinking that the other nation might have better models.

I would go so far as to say that, just as Winner mentioned about nuclear, these huge data centres that individuals like Altman (Altman 2023) or Kevin O’Leary (Mytton 2021) want to build are totalitarian by definition, and we should pursue the improvement of local models over these huge buildings that lessen the quality of life of their neighbours by drinking their water and increasing their electricity bills.

If the only direction is forward, Winner’s lesson must be our driving force. We need to think critically about the consequences for society. I like (Benanti 2023b)’s auto-mobile metaphor for this: it is not enough to have effective brakes and know how to use them, nor is it enough that the production process is transparent, not even knowing how to drive the car; the real question is, where do we want to go? I am not suggesting we follow the Catholic church’s ‘Rome Call for AI Ethics’ as the framework to implement an AI society, but at least they are considering Winner and thinkers alike. One thing is certain: our AI future must be decided by all of us.

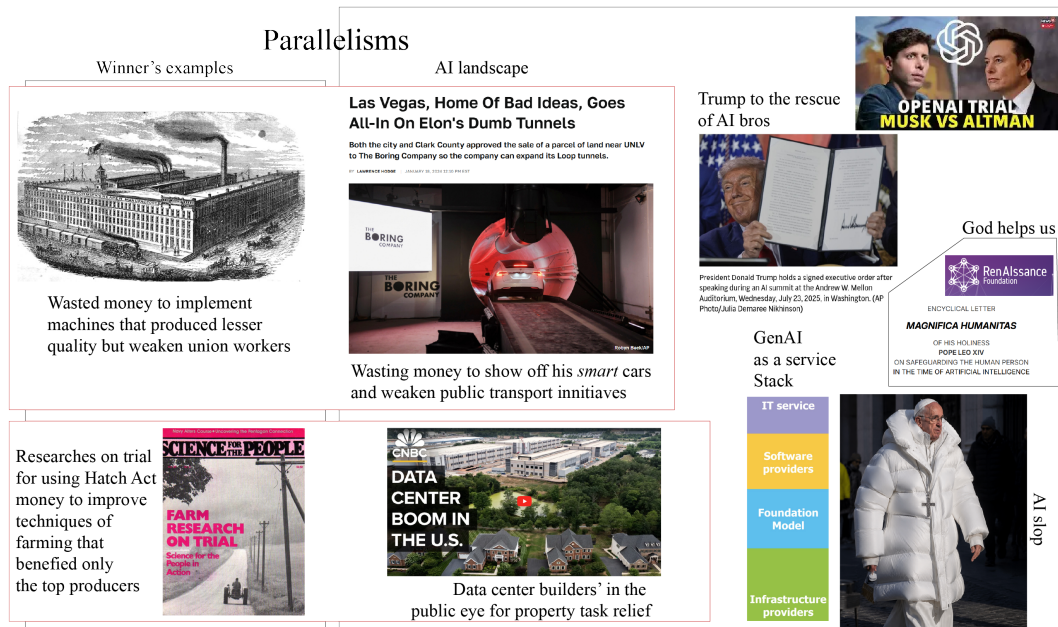


Figure 2: Infographic - Some ideas could not be explored in the main text.

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